r/Warehouseworkers • 2mo ago
u/Lethalogicax

# Our forklift batteries are in such bad shape that they start to boil while charging and it triggers the overtemp safety shutdown on the chargers...




It's only showing 14 minutes of charge because I unplugged it for a minute before plugging it back in again to see if it would fault again...

Yep... Battery acid is literally boiling inside our batteries while charging... The sulfur smell burns your nose and throat over at the battery change station. It's horrible...

And naturally, the boss won't do anything about it because "we're getting new forklifts soon" and "the new machines have built-in batteries so it's no use replacing these"... and until then we get to burn our nostrils with sulfur gases I guess...

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Fgchavez • 2mo ago

Who waters your batteries? Most forklift drivers on my shift fill it up after we get changes.

17 Reply ···

Lethalogicax OP • 2mo ago

Yep, that is our policy. Refill the water everytime you change your battery. We have a watering system equiped on our batteries so it's super easy. A network of hoses going to each cell cap, and a special valve in each that closes when the fluid level is perfect so there's no guess work.

Despite that, our batteries are so old and poorly maintained that they overheat, boil, and sometimes just refuse to charge outright...

11 Reply ···

boytekka • 2mo ago

Lucky for you guys that you can just refill the water easily, for us, we have to remove the entire battery just to refill the water in each cell, its a chore so most of the people dont want to refill it

7 Reply ···

Sensitive-Car4949 • 2mo ago

Wtf?! You have to change your own battery and fill the water? That's just begging for something to get fucked up, lol.

6 Reply ···

RichardBCummintonite • 2mo ago

Yeah some places I worked were just a small warehouse attached to a store, so we

forklift mechanics to handle something so important that could easily be fucked up.

At my current job, we have a couple people who are certified to change batteries if we really need it (I'm one), but we don't water them or do any maintenance and we try to avoid changes unless absolutely necessary. Instead, a company comes out once a week and waters them and does check ups. We aren't allowed to do any sort of mechanical work

3 Reply ...

Sensitive-Car4949 • 2mo ago

Yeah any company expecting non maintenance employees to do anything mechanical is fucked and likely won't last.

3 Reply ...

Paralystic • 2mo ago

We have to change our own batteries and if a battery is low on water we refill them but we also have a guy who comes in and refills them all for us. Does someone change your battery for you or do you just plug it up? We have like 40 forklifts 25 extra batteries and 1 changing room

2 Reply ...

Sensitive-Car4949 • 2mo ago

I usually piss into the water reservoir to save time on bathroom breaks.

1 Reply ...

Z28Malibu4life • 2mo ago

Those systems are convenient but are prone to failure. We ripped ours out due to cells not getting filled with water and then cooking like yours. I believe those systems are to be pulled once a month to ensure the cells are getting water. We decided since we have to pull them once a month it was easier to just use regular caps and use the water gun that's for open cells. Way fewer issues since.

Teondar • 2mo ago

Are you plugging them in right after watering them? If you are, don't do that.

8 Reply ···

Lethalogicax OP • 2mo ago

Nope, opposite way around is policy for us. Water immediately after charging

5 Reply ···

Teondar • 2mo ago

Yeah that's what I said. Weird then, I guess there's multiple reasons but that's usually the first one.

3 Reply ···

RealAlienTwo • 2mo ago

You might want to have someone come in and take a look at that. Could impact operational ability if not addressed, also not safe in any way shape or form.

2 Reply ···

Lethalogicax OP • 2mo ago

Oh, believe me, we've tried... This man has the audacity to literally never call the battery tech in to do routine maintenance, and then somehow be *SHOCKED* when the batteries start melting down... It is so so far away from safe, and he's just shooting himself in the foot for later when the batteries are failing several years before they should be. He won't listen. He never listens.

1 Reply ···

RealAlienTwo • 2mo ago

If you're in the states, you can anonymously contact OSHA... This kind of shit boggles the mind, there is a cost but the cost of doing nothing is way higher. If you're unable to move loads while this is down, that adds exponentially to the cost, and this is assuming all team-members end up uninjured.

Life-Is-A-Bad-Trip • 2mo ago

When I lived on a farm we had a few old beater golf carts. Battery bank under the seat. They would do the same. They tended to get worse in regards to boiling right before they shit the bed.

So, if they're anything alike maybe you'll have new batteries relatively soon. Whatever relatively means idk.

3 Reply ···

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JustForkIt1111one • 2mo ago

The boiling + overtemp shutdowns + sulfur smell mean these batteries are already damaged and unsafe to keep using this way. Continuing will only accelerate failure, create more hydrogen gas and acid vapor exposure, and risk further charger trips or worse. The watering system needs inspection/repair (or replacement of the valves), the batteries need proper evaluation (specific gravity checks, equalization if still salvageable), and management's "new machines soon" approach is putting people at risk of acid exposure and poor air quality.

3 Reply ···

Jacktheforkie • 2mo ago

It literally is a 5 dollar fix, get some tap water in it, it might shorten the lifespan but it's not a massive amount

2 Reply ···

A100921 • 2mo ago

Filling it with water after every charge? Probably have way too much in them and it's boiling over.

2 Reply ···

I'm discovering now that it might actually be the thing silently sabotaging us... Those valves have literally never been replaced and they're like >5yrs old now. I'm pretty sure we have cell cap indicators that are sticking in place and falsely showing a full cell, when it's actually dangerously low on fluid. But if the float is stuck, then water never enters the cell during refilling and the indicator continues to show full!

1 Reply ···



rasputinrasputin • 2mo ago

Time to send in a sneaky lil OSHA report

2 Reply ···



Forklift_Messiah • 2mo ago

I sell forklifts for a living and I've walked into a lot of battery rooms that smell like yours. Couple things.

That sulfur smell is the part I'd focus on. Normal gassing at the end of a charge is hydrogen and it doesn't smell like anything. If it's burning your nose and throat, you're smelling hydrogen sulfide, and lead-acid only puts that off when a cell is shorted or the battery is going into thermal runaway. So this isn't just "tired old batteries." Something specific is wrong.

What's happening is a bad cell has low internal resistance, so it hogs the current and gets hot, and the heat drops the resistance more, so it pulls more current, and around it goes. Your charger shutting down is the only thing stopping that. Honestly the charger is the hero here. And the fact that it faulted again 14 minutes after you unplugged and replugged tells you the battery never cooled off, it just picked right back up where it left off.

If you want to figure out which battery is actually the problem, grab a hydrometer and read every cell after a charge attempt. One cell way down from the rest, or one that won't come up at all, that's your bad one. Takes five minutes and it's the most useful thing you can do. While you're in there check your water levels, because plates sitting above the waterline will cook, and low water causes this more than anything else. If you've got an IR thermometer, shoot the cell tops too, the hot spot will tell you right where it is.

Other things worth ruling out. Is it one battery or all of them? If everything faults on every charger, somebody may have

battery temp should be, so check that the temp probe lead is actually plugged into the battery. And if guys are pulling batteries off a truck and slapping them straight on the charger with no cooldown, that could do it.

On the boss thing. Charging rooms have to be ventilated under OSHA 1910.178(g), and you're supposed to have eyewash and drench facilities close by. Hydrogen is explosive at 4 percent in air. This isn't a comfort complaint, it's a fire and exposure issue.

What I've seen actually work: write down every fault. Date, time, battery number, charger number. Email it to your supervisor and whoever handles safety so there's a timestamp on it. Then call whoever sells you your batteries and ask for a battery health test. Most of us do them free and give you a written report. A piece of paper from an outside company saying the pack is unserviceable moves a boss in a way that an employee saying it never does.

And "we're getting new trucks soon" isn't an answer. New equipment shows up when it shows up, sometimes a year late. The fire risk is right now.

2 Reply ···

Lethalogicax OP • 2mo ago

Thank you for the response!

I think I figured out the problem here. I bought a TDS meter and checked the water coming out of the water de-ionizer/purifier cartridge. Control tap water was 170ppm, test water coming out of the filter was 150ppm! The cartridge is spent, multiple times over. This whole time, we have been poisoning our batteries with what is essentially tap water...

1 Reply ···

BrooksPuuntai • 2mo ago

Guessing your watering system isn't actually filling all the cells. If you smell sulfur then one or a few cells aren't getting water. Similar thing was happening to one of our lifts, watered and green light on battery for water, but when a tech came out he mentioned 2 cells weren't getting water.

2 Reply ···

Lethalogicax OP • 2mo ago

system. The floats are very delicate and are prone to getting gunked up and seizing. When a float gets worn out, buoyancy will still raise the float into the closed position, but gravity is not enough to pull the seized float down when the fluid level falls. The float stays up, seized in place, and then falsely reports a full cell while also holding the valve closed and preventing that cell from ever getting any water at all! You look at the cell caps, see that the floats are all raised, the watering system stops accepting any more water, and you are lead to think that you've fully filled every cell. Now the operator has no way of knowing that one of those cells is nearly dry and they leave the battery station believing that they've done everything correctly.

It seems that this has lead to a huge problem within the company trying to figure out where to point the pointy fingers of blame. The battery tech tells our boss that tons of battery cells are bone dry. Then the bossman yells at us because he thinks we aren't following protocol. We argue back saying that we are following procedure, but he doesn't believe us because the techs are saying the batteries are not getting watered... and so now none of us trust eachother...

1 Reply ···

Jabberwocky696 • 2mo ago

Good it will work till the next inspection.

1 Reply ···

Potential_Roll_6266 • 2mo ago

Hope you guys get your new lifts soon if the company wont address this problem!!!...unfortunately thats common in aging electric truck fleets :( your battery is supposed to bubble and gas during charge...thats part of the battery releasing the acid from the plates and accepting the charge and the gas is hydrogen gas (flammable btw) from the process. The smell is cell sulfation typically from under watering or not fully discharging the battery down to 10% before fully charging so the acid doesn't flow in and out of the plates properly and the sulfuric acid bonds to the lead plates. Only way to break that is to basically fully discharge and then cook the crap out of the battery for a few cycles. Make sure they are equalize charged at least weekly...wont fix it now but will help moving forward.

1 Reply ···

Opportune charge or something like that.Thankfully we don't have to fill it with water. The batteries are shit here. Some you have to charge everytime you are waiting to leave some you only have to charge on break or at the end of the day. They keep saying they are getting new machines for us but I doubt it. The ones we use now only half ass work

1 Reply ···

Emotional_Smell_6521 • 2mo ago

These chargers suck ass too btw...

1 Reply ···